



The Social History of Canada Series

Author(s): H. V. Nelles

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ESSAY IN REVIEW

The Social History of Canada Series

The University of Toronto Press launched its Social History of Canada series in 1971 with a collection of pathetic letters written by destitute Canadians to R.B. Bennett. With the publication of the League for Social Reconstruction's answer to the depression amongst the latest batch of titles, the series has come full circle and to a temporary halt. It's time, perhaps, to stand back and take stock. (If you have a pipe, puff sagely.)

In a little over four years Michael Bliss has presented us with a daunting shelf of novels, anthologies, reprints, royal commissions and documents on subjects as diverse as immigration, Americanization, the women's movement, railroad building, urban reform, agrarianism, the condition of the working class, progressivism, homesteading, Louis Riel, Newfoundland, nativism and religious nationalism. Only in Canada would someone be asked to review such a disparate library of reprints, and only a fool would try. One might as well attempt a commentary on the Press' lesser known and vastly more expensive Scholarly Reprint Series. (But how do you say no to friends?)

What is there about our condition that inspires such relentless self-examination? The Americans seem to get by without reviewing the Krauss Reprint catalogue or, for that matter, any of the 124 series (4,396 volumes) re-issued by the Arno Press. Shouldn't we just thank Michael Bliss for his energy and the University of Toronto Press for its enterprise and leave it at that? Why would anyone think that there was something to be said about a bunch of second editions?

Could it be the novelty of the thing? Hardly. The Carleton Library and Coles Canadiana Collection have been with us longer, and unreviewed as a series. Is it creeping Canadian Councilism? We've become conditioned to writing assessments – any subject, quick, confidential, cheap. (“Too ambitious, can't be completed in the time allotted.” “Methodologically primitive.” “Why no representation from the Maritimes?” etc.) Perhaps the urge is simply instinct, an entirely natural reaction in a country where more effort is put into reviewing books than writing them and where there are almost as many editors with space to fill as authors. (There are presently more than 200 journals being published in Canada – and seeking subventions – in the humanities and social sciences alone!) On the other hand perhaps our sense of civic duty demands that The Social History of Canada be appraised. It has been supported by public funds, after all, and in this time of fiscal restraint every expenditure must be subjected to the most searching scrutiny. Apparently the University of Toronto Press did receive something like \$30,000 to subsidize publication of the series – or about the amount that the SSRCC blows on one of its annual and entirely ephemeral conferences. But compared to a hundred thousand dollars or so for the Loyalists, a few hundred thousand each for Mill, Yeats and Erasmus, half a million for Disraeli's letters, three-quarter of a million to up-date the Encyclopedia Canadiana, a million to collect documents on the history of Canadian theatre, another million to study the influence of parties in the Canadian political process, and two million dollars to publish nine volumes of documents on British Columbia history up to 1871, \$30,000 for 28 books sounds like a bargain. In the academic barnyard The Social History of Canada series gets only a very small space at the trough.

It has been suggested that I might use this review to reflect upon the state of social history in Canada. Hmm. The trouble with that is that none of the works reprinted was originally conceived as a study in social history – yes, including Cleverdon. Nor can the editors and introducers be considered social historians. Most of them, in fact, are intellectual or political historians disguised for the occasion. Finally, this line of attack collapses completely after a few words with the general editor. (What conception of social history – manners and mores, mentalités, structure or class – guided you in the selection of titles?) He quite candidly admits that all he wanted to do was publish a high class reprint series. The title was chosen by the salesman at the Press who liked the sound of it. (“Woody”, I believe, is the way Python would have put it.) No coherent theory holds the series together at all. It is, in many respects, a series of convenience. Some manuscripts, submitted to the Press for other purposes, were slotted in as the Press saw fit. Others were rejected because it was supposed they wouldn’t sell. Some of the volumes issued might more logically have appeared in the Canadian Problems Series, or in the University of Toronto Press’ own list of literary reprints. So, where does that leave us? If The Rapids and Canada and the Canadian Question are social history, what isn’t? I suppose now, even Mackenzie King’s Diary qualifies.

The general editor convinced the University of Toronto Press that there were a large number of important out-of-print books and documents that could quite usefully and profitably be re-published with scholarly introductions in a modest paperback format for the swelling university market. The Carleton Library history division had become moribund – it has perked up lately in response to the competition – and the books Bliss had in mind were unlikely to be of interest to the nostalgia breeders at Coles. The Press, which saw its chance to get in on the reprint action, jumped at the idea. How were the titles chosen? Michael’s friends often accuse him of reprinting all of the books on the reading list for Ramsey Cook’s seminar, and when he got to the end he stopped. Not true. (But close.) Professor Cook not only refuses to recognize T.C. Keefer for the great Canadian intellectual he was, he even denies his existence, and Phillips Thompson’s name could not be spoken at the University of Toronto – let alone appear on a reading list – from the riots of 1895 until the labour history revival of the late sixties. The truth, as usual, is more prosaic. Bliss started with a list of books in mind and accepted suggestions put to him by his friends – mainly Ramsay Cook and Carl Berger. However, once the series got off the ground, people from all over the country came forward with proposals.

Were Bliss’ original premises correct? Were there a lot of important books that deserved republication and was there a market waiting for them? One at a time. Without question the series has served the profession well by making more conveniently available a number of standard authors: Goldwin Smith, J.S. Woodsworth, the young William Lyon Mackenzie King, Stephen Leacock, Louis Aubrey Wood and Nellie McClung. In my view the series has also brought to light the work of some lesser known figures which can still be read with profit: E.W. Bradwin, H.B. Ames, T.C. Keefer, John MacDougall, Salem Bland, Catherine Cleverdon, and Douglas Durkin among others. The importance of the condensed reports, edited documents and anthologies depends more directly upon a user’s needs. Considered as a whole I believe that The Social History of Canada series has substantially enriched our school and university library collections and has been of enormous benefit to teachers of Canadian history. For this the general editor and the Press deserve the heartiest congratulations of the profession.

But what of the second part of the proposition? Were there large numbers of teachers eager to assign such books and masses of students slaving to buy them? In the marketplace the series has been far from successful. I expect that as far as the University of Toronto Press is concerned the high point came with the publication of the first volume, The Wretched of Canada (story in Time, laudatory reviews in all the newspapers, brisk sales), and it has been downhill – with the odd pleasant surprise – ever since. Professors may well be assigning the series – if only to get the freebies – but students aren't buying. Or perhaps Bliss and the Press over-estimated the size and appetite of the CanHist demand. Looking at the question strictly from a market point of view, the only books which have warranted re-issue have been those which managed one way or another to break out of the narrow college classification like The Wretched of Canada which received broad general circulation, or those which managed to catch a trend, like Canada and the Canadian Question during the surge of popular nationalism, and Nellie McClung and Catherine Cleverdon during the current feminist consciousness raising. There is, however, one notable exception to the rule, By Great Waters, the Newfoundland and Labrador anthology, which is the series' best seller. (First rule of Canadian publishing: books on Newfoundland sell – at least in Newfoundland. It's a province with centralized school book purchasing and there are a lot of schools in Newfoundland.)

Some of the titles, I'm told, have established a regular if modest annual sale for courses in Canadian history – the purpose for which they were intended. Wood's A History of Farmers' Movements in Canada, Bradwin's The Bunkhouse Man, Ames' The City Below The Hill, Canada Investigates Industrialism, Leacock's Unsolved Riddle, The Queen v. Louis Riel, and perhaps two or three others will probably justify the investment put into them by the University of Toronto Press. But for the rest, it is either too early to tell, or altogether too obvious that if some people thought they should be published, not many needed them enough to buy them. Eventually the Press might break even on the whole series, but at the moment it is distinctly in the hole. I expect that before any new titles are added to the list, some of the old titles will have to start moving more actively than they have in the past. And who could blame the Press for that. It has taken a lot of nerve to get this far. The accountants are not likely to draw much consolation from the fact that the series has been judged an intellectual success.

What if one were to approach The Social History of Canada as if it were a federal cabinet and ask if the traditional religious, ethnic, ideological and regional categories were filled in the proper proportions? Type of material, topic, regional emphasis and period might stand as the corresponding historical classifications. Michael Bliss and his editors have undeniably offered up a remarkable variety of fare: court records, pamphlets, royal commission reports, bad novels, memoirs, tracts great and small, letters and collected essays besides academic monographs. Topically, the series has been wide-ranging, and on reflection, surprisingly balanced in its treatment of agrarianism and urban reform, urban workers and frontier labourers, Orange and Bleu nationalism, the varieties of nativism, and the ideological spectrum of social criticism. Quite evidently effort has been directed toward the achievement of regional coverage, the west being particularly well represented and the Maritimes being slighted yet again. Only in the area of period coverage can the series be found seriously wanting. Most of the titles focus upon the late nineteenth and early twentieth centuries, what might loosely be called the progressive era. This bias quite clearly reflects the general editor's own research interests. The pre-confederation and New France periods are totally ignored and so too are the wartime upheavals of the twentieth century. But anyone who

makes this charge is obliged to come forward with some appropriate titles which have not already been published and which might possibly find something more than a library sale. The Champlain Society, the various Record Societies, Coles and the large American reprint houses have been concentrating largely in the colonial period; so perhaps this requirement is met elsewhere.

Finally, the scholarly introductions. Did they add enough to justify the trouble and expense? The vast majority of the introductions are solid, informative essays which provide the necessary context, biographical information and critical reaction, to the appended text. Several suffer mightily in comparison with what follows. But on the other hand three or four strike me as being important and original contributions in their own right which rise well above the limits of the document being commented upon. (I am thinking especially of Greg Kealey on the background to the Royal Commission on the Relations of Labor and Capital, Bliss and Grayson on the Great Depression, Arthur Silver on the state of mind of late nineteenth century French Canada, and Paul Rutherford on urban reform.) Those getting-the-record-straight prefaces by the LSR and Leonard Marsh only serve to point out the need for proper critical assessments of the intellectual origins of the Canadian welfare state – but perhaps it is too soon for that. One literary executor was so insistent that history should record the correct (i.e. his) view of a work, that he held up publication until the offending introduction was removed. The book has subsequently appeared elsewhere with a scholarly introduction by the literary executor.

Well, having said all of this, what is there to conclude? I suppose everyone has a list of books that should have been published in the series, and I know some who have notions about books they believe should never have appeared. There will, no doubt, be pressure to make the series more properly a social history series, to make it reflect more accurately the work being done presently in structural analysis and class history. There will also be lobbying for more collections of essays, documents and so forth – these being the easiest things to think up. The list of improvements is endless. But I vote we all pronounce the series a great success, clap Michael on the back for doing all the hard work for us, congratulate the Press for its service to the profession, and get back to work writing our own books. What an astonishing idea, reprints of books that have never been published before with critical introductions by the authors!

H.V. Nelles
York University